

Social linking

Facebook will soon offer Twitter linking to all users. Rejoice all ye netizens!

Here with vigour

A leaked Radio Shack roadmap indicates HTC Vigor could be available in stores by 20 October 2011

HOW WE TESTED

For a clearer division of phones for this test, we lined them up according to the prices (prevailing market prices, not the MRP). This is because we've noticed that there's usually quite a difference between the box price of the phone, and its actual selling price in the market.

Before beginning the test process, we ensured that all phones were returned to their factory settings. Software updates were all installed to ensure that we were testing the phone with the software version you're likely to buy it with. We've divided the table and rated the phones on three basic parameters: features, build and ergonomics; and performance.

While "features" doesn't have any testable parameters, we rated the phone on features like camera specs, hot-swappable ability of memory card, connectivity options and even the user interface. Under the "build and ergonomics" section, we rated the phone on things like design, build quality, surface materials used and the quality of moving parts – something as small as a USB port cover to a slide out keypad. Also rated is the comfort

factor of the phone, the quality and design of the keypad, placement of various keys and the usability of the entire package in general.

We test the "performance" of a phone through a series of tests. First, we divide our call clarity test into three zones, on the basis of network signal strength. Zone 1 and Zone 2 represent normal usage in city scenario with excellent to mediocre signal reception. Zone 3 is the real test though – poor network where the phone shows below 25 per cent of signal strength. We rated calls on the basis of clarity on both sides of the line, presence of distortion, factors like call drops and so on. Loudspeaker, earpiece, hands-free clarity and volume levels on call were also tested. Music quality was tested using two MP3 files encoded at 320 kbps constant bit rate.

The phone's camera was tested for colour reproduction and sharpness of focus as well as the detail level it's capable of. All these scores are rated on a subjective scale of 10. Finally, we graded the phone's display itself – resolution and crispness, colour and its visibility in sunlight.



Samsung Galaxy S

And the winner is: Considering the price and performance, the Acer Liquid Metal comes out as the winner in comparison to its rivals. It manages to do consistently well across the ratings. If it's an Android phone you want in this price bracket, this is the phone to check out.

₹18K - ₹20K

The highest price bracket is usually the most cut-throat in terms of competition. We've noticed this in most product comparisons that we do. In this case, the arrival of the Samsung Galaxy S and the Apple iPhone 3GS 8GB, thanks to individual price revisions, means that devices that were once in a much higher price category are now the ones the other phones have to compete with. While the likes of the



Apple iPhone 3GS

LG Optimus Black may feel hard done by this, the consumer definitely isn't complaining.

Features, build and usability: The Motorola Milestone XT800 is by far the heaviest of the lot. While the display quality is quite okay, the bulky form factor works against it. The XT800, surprisingly, doesn't feel as expensive as it actually is. The LG Optimus Black is a classy looking device. It falls into the big screen device category with its 4-inch display, but somehow doesn't feel big. The Samsung Galaxy S, on the other hand, looks and feels like a smartphone with a 4-inch display. Finally, the Apple iPhone 3GS, with its looks and build, it has for long set the benchmark for other smartphones. While it may be considered heavy

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Apple	Bharti Airtel / Aircel	NA	NA	www.apple.com
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HTC	HTC India Pvt. Ltd.	1800-1033-566	NA	www.htc.com